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# Participation Report on the CSCPT 2026 Cybersecurity Bootcamp

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# Introduction

This report documents my participation in the final selection bootcamp of the Cybersecurity Challenge PT 2026 (CSCPT 2026), a national initiative for identifying and developing talent in the field of cybersecurity. Throughout the document I describe, in chronological order, my entire journey, from the online training phase to the in-person bootcamp in Rio Maior, as well as the results I achieved at each stage and a critical assessment of the experience.

The Cybersecurity Challenge PT is organised by the Portuguese National Cybersecurity Centre (CNCS) and aims to select and prepare the national representatives for international cybersecurity competitions. The final selection bootcamp took place from 17 to 20 July 2026 and brought together 30 participants, of which I was one.

I have also included in this report a list of figures that visually accompanies the main moments and locations of the event, allowing me to contextualise each stage I describe.



# Background and Organisation of the Bootcamp

In Portugal, the bootcamp was promoted by the Cybersecurity Challenge PT, an initiative organised by the Portuguese National Cybersecurity Centre (CNCS). The first competition day took place on the international OMNI CTF platform, which placed the Portuguese participants competing side by side with competitors from all over the world.

## Platforms and links

Throughout the whole programme, several official platforms and channels were used, both for the training and selection phase and for the competition and for following the communications:

- Cybersecurity Challenge PT website: <https://cybersecuritychallenge.pt>
- Training platform: <https://training.cybersecuritychallenge.pt>
- Cybersecurity Challenge PT LinkedIn: <https://www.linkedin.com/company/cscpt/>
- CNCS, Portuguese National Cybersecurity Centre LinkedIn: <https://www.linkedin.com/company/centro-nacional-de-ciberseguranca---portuguese-national-cybersecurity-centre/>
- OMNI CTF website: <https://omnictf.com>
- OMNI CTF Discord: <https://discord.gg/4Kd37tfyq>
- Cybersecurity Challenge PT Discord: <https://discord.com/invite/DUZmjnyUqk>



## Venue and dates

The final selection bootcamp (CSCPT 2026) took place from 17 to 20 July 2026, in Rio Maior, with 30 participants. All the work was carried out in the offices of the Rio Maior Multi-Sports Pavilion, part of the local sports complex and located right next to the main football pitch. This pavilion is usually intended for indoor sports (handball, futsal, basketball and volleyball), but it is in this area that the offices we used are located, with a gym on the lower floor. Meals were served at the canteen of the Rio Maior Sports Centre, in the Training Centre of the Rio Maior Sports Complex, on Av. Paulo VI.

## Accommodation

Participants were distributed across two different hotels, both very close to the competition venue. I describe each of them below.

### Hotel Paulo VI

The Hotel Paulo VI was the originally planned accommodation for the bootcamp and is located in the same complex, on Av. Paulo VI. It had its own entrance and reception, a bar and lounge area and a space for meals, offering good comfort conditions to those who stayed there.



Figure 1 – Hotel Paulo VI, entrance.





Figure 2 – Hotel Paulo VI, reception.



Figure 3 – Hotel Paulo VI, bar and lounge.



Figure 4 – Hotel Paulo VI, dining area.





## Sienna Hotel

The Sienna Hotel was about 2 minutes from the Hotel Paulo VI and hosted half of the participants, since the Hotel Paulo VI did not have enough rooms for everyone. It had a reception area, a bar, a dining room and also a rooftop terrace, being an equally comfortable and well-located accommodation.



Figure 5 – Sienna Hotel, reception.



Figure 6 – Sienna Hotel, reception area.





Figure 7 – Sienna Hotel, bar.



Figure 8 – Sienna Hotel, dining area.



Figure 9 – Sienna Hotel, rooftop terrace.



# Timeline and Development of the Bootcamp

## Online training phase

My participation began with the launch of the Cybersecurity Challenge PT training platform. Registration was open between 19 February and 18 June 2026 and, during that period, three training challenges were released each week. It was in this phase that I came into contact with the great variety of categories and exercises that exist and where I learned a lot, practising consistently over several months. I finished this phase ranked in 1st place, out of 236 participants.

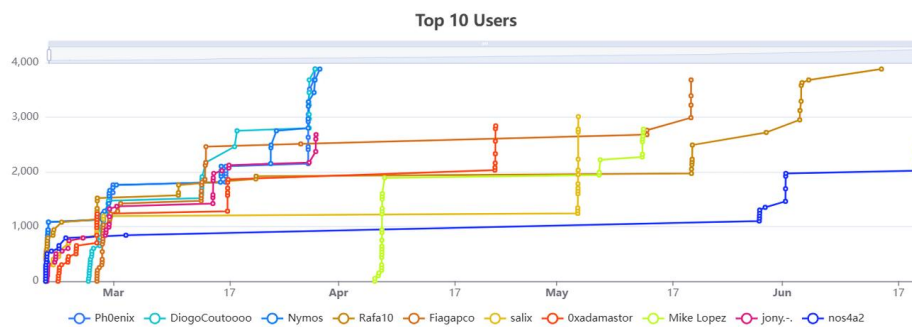


Figure 10 – Leaderboard of the Cybersecurity Challenge PT training platform, 1st place out of 236 participants.



## Qualification CTF

Once the training phase was over, the bootcamp qualification competition took place on 20 June 2026. It was a jeopardy-style CTF, online and individual, lasting 10 hours (from 9 a.m. to 7 p.m.). As in the training phase, this competition covered different categories and required entirely individual work, acting as the final filter for access to the bootcamp. This CTF determined the 30 participants selected; I ranked in 13th place, out of roughly 100 competitors, which secured my selection.

|    |                               |          |      |
|----|-------------------------------|----------|------|
| 1  | uxignitngu1337                | Sêniores | 1471 |
| 2  | Rafa                          | Sêniores | 1471 |
| 3  | KLPP                          | Sêniores | 1141 |
| 4  | Uzk3                          | Sêniores | 1061 |
| 5  | Devia estar a estudar MAT A 🤔 | Juniões  | 911  |
| 6  | s1gn3rs                       | Sêniores | 801  |
| 7  | varanda                       | Sêniores | 801  |
| 8  | vLad                          | Sêniores | 801  |
| 9  | nos4a2                        | Sêniores | 771  |
| 10 | afsc19                        | Sêniores | 771  |
| 11 | Nymos                         | Sêniores | 771  |
| 12 | t0rr3s                        | Sêniores | 771  |
| 13 | Ph0enix                       | Sêniores | 721  |
| 14 | Reber                         | Sêniores | 671  |
| 15 | dinofan                       | Sêniores | 591  |
| 16 | gprata                        | Juniões  | 471  |

Figure 11 – Leaderboard of the bootcamp selection platform, 13th place out of roughly 100 participants.





## Arrival in Rio Maior and accommodation

The in-person bootcamp took place from 17 to 20 July 2026, in Rio Maior. I arrived on 17 July, the day on which I checked in and was informed about where I would be staying.



**Figure 12 – Arrival in Rio Maior and check-in for hotel accommodation assignment.**

As I mentioned earlier, participants were distributed between the Hotel Paulo VI and the Sienna Hotel, both just a few minutes from the venue where the challenges took place.





## Opening day and rules

Still on 17 July, we headed to the offices of the Rio Maior Multi-Sports Pavilion. In a presentation room, we met the organisers and the event jury, as well as all the competition rules, of which the following stand out:

- The use of LLMs was not allowed.
- Forming teams or helping one another between participants was not allowed; everyone competed on their own.

One aspect I particularly liked was the way the organisers “broke the ice” among everyone: each person introduced themselves and shared a fun fact about themselves, which immediately helped to create a good atmosphere among the participants.



Figure 13 – Bootcamp opening day.



Figure 14 – Bootcamp organisers and jury.



Figure 15 – Group photo with all bootcamp participants.



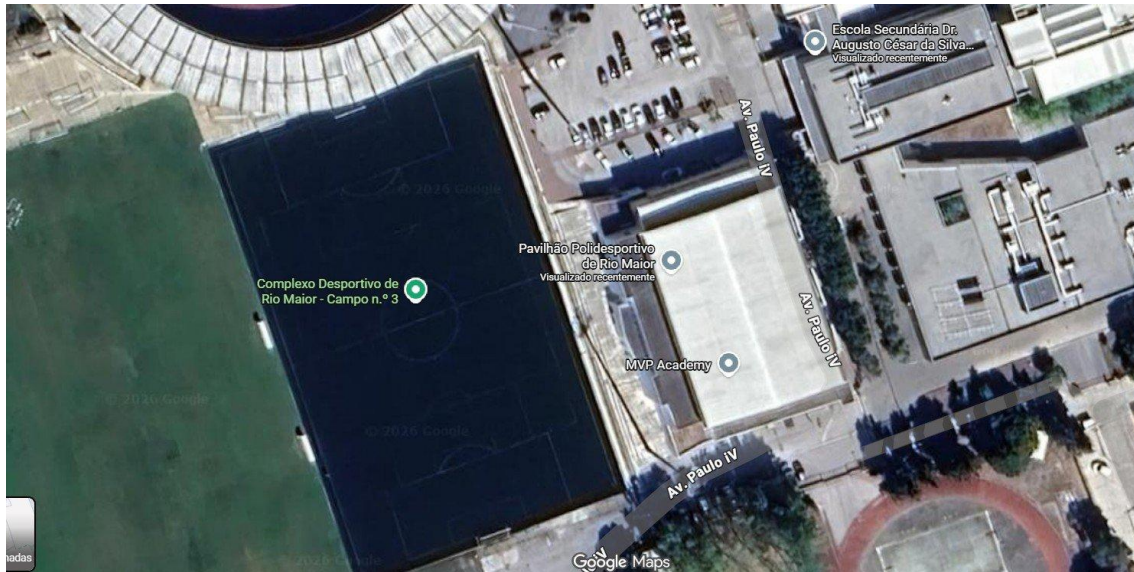


Figure 16 – Area where all the CTF challenges took place.



## Meals

Meals were had at the canteen of the Rio Maior Sports Centre, in the Training Centre of the Rio Maior Sports Complex, on Av. Paulo VI, part of the same complex as the stadium, the swimming pools and the sports pavilions. It is a canteen designed to feed high-performance athletes, which explains the strong connection to sport of those who pass through; the space even includes a pavilion with a reception area and several boards with photographs and crests of football, futsal and other teams that have trained or passed through there.



Figure 17 – Canteen of the Rio Maior Sports Centre, where meals were served.





Figure 18 – Dining space of the Rio Maior Sports Centre canteen.



Figure 19 – A meal served at the Rio Maior Sports Centre canteen.



## First competition day: OMNI CTF

On the first competition day, we woke up at 7:30 a.m. for breakfast and at 8:30 a.m. we headed to the challenge venue.

On this day we competed on the international OMNI CTF platform, where we were competing with 786 participants from all over the world. The CTF included several categories: MISC, PWN, Reverse, Forensics, Crypto, Games, Web and my favourite category, OSINT.

In our bootcamp there was a time limit, until 6:00 p.m.; after that we wrote the writeups for the exercises we had solved and went to dinner. When the time to submit flags ended, I ranked in 186th place in the division ranking, ahead of all the other Portuguese competitors, with 5 flags: 2 in Crypto, 1 in Web and 2 in OSINT. In one of the OSINT exercises I was among the first (top 10) to find the flag as soon as the challenge was released. It is worth noting that OSINT was the category with the fewest solves. I then wrote the writeups for the OSINT exercises, which were the ones I most enjoyed solving.



Figure 20 – A photo of me with NYMOS upon arriving at the venue where the challenge took place.



Figure 21 – OMNI CTF leaderboard (first day of the bootcamp), among 786 participants worldwide.



## Second competition day: internal CTF

On the second day we kept the same schedule. This time, we no longer competed on the OMNI CTF, but on an internal CTF created by the bootcamp organisers themselves. This custom CTF did not include the OSINT category, nor some others: it featured only the categories that had also appeared in the training CTF and the selection CTF, namely Crypto, Reverse, Forensics, PWN and Web.

Despite not featuring my favourite category, I kept solving exercises and finished the day with 4 flags, being 3 in Forensics and 1 in Reverse, reaching a final ranking of 5th place on the leaderboard, among the 30 participants. As on the previous day, we ended with writeups of the exercises of our choice.

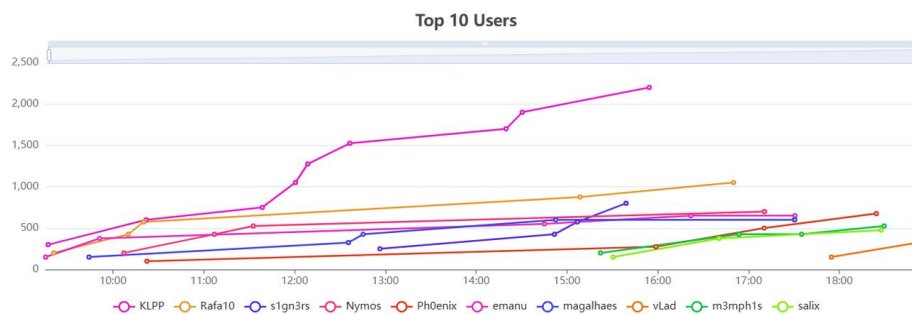


Figure 22 – Leaderboard of the bootcamp internal CTF (second and final competition day), 5th place out of 30 participants.





## Results day

On the last day we found out who had been selected for the next phase, Team Portugal 2026. We once again went to the Rio Maior Sports Centre, to a presentation room with the trophies on the jury table. It was there that the participants who would advance were announced. I was not selected but, even so, I was very satisfied with my performance: I learned a great deal and met very intelligent people, several with far more years of experience in this kind of challenge than I have. I take from this experience a lot of new knowledge and contact with a very strong national cybersecurity community.



Figure 23 – Group photo with Team Portugal 2026.



## OMNI CTF certificate of participation

After the competition, OMNI CTF shared on their Discord a Google Drive link with a participation diploma. This certificate recognises my active participation in the OmniCTF 2026 Qualifiers, described as a cybersecurity competition built around skill, creativity and perseverance, and it is a nice memento of my journey throughout the event.

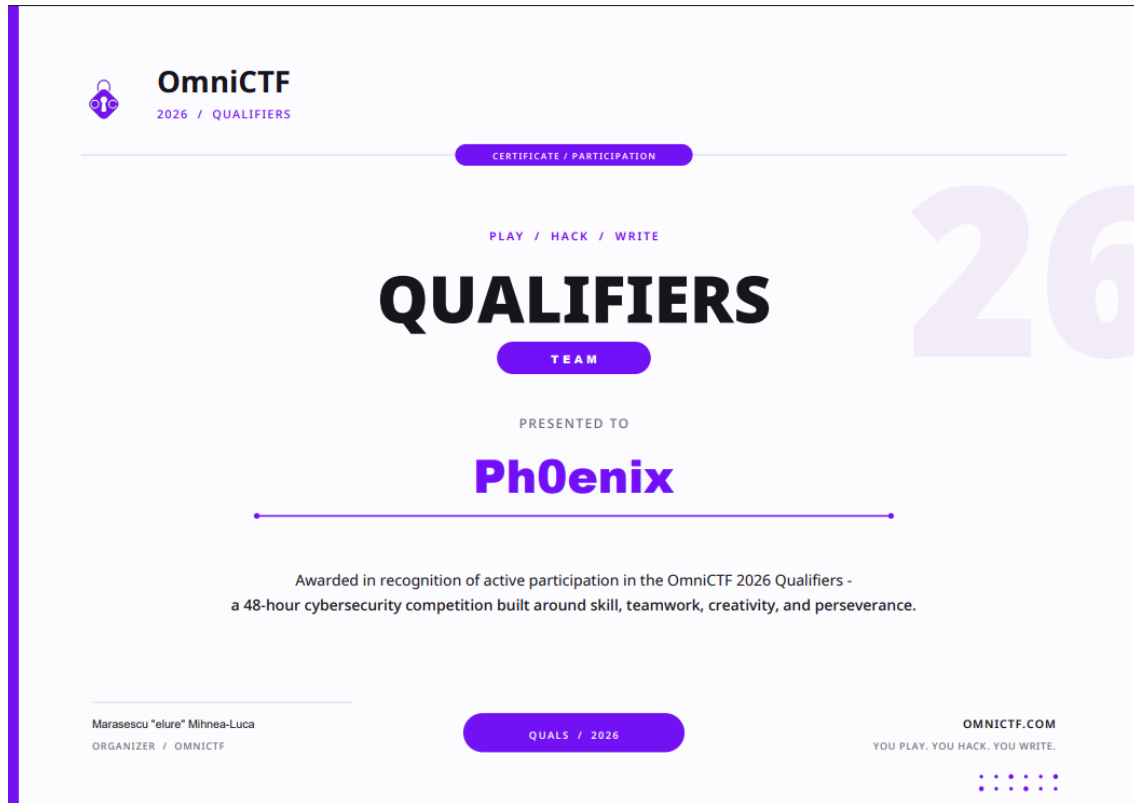


Figure 24 – Certificate of participation in the OmniCTF 2026 Qualifiers, sent by OMNI CTF via their Discord.



## Critical Analysis and Recommendations

Overall, the experience was very positive, both in terms of the people and the professionalism of the CTFs, the facilities and the food. Even so, I would like to leave a few constructive criticisms.

### OMNI CTF: unequal enforcement of the rules

At the OMNI CTF, the rules were not applied equally worldwide. There were rumours that, in certain countries or regions, some participants were allowed to use LLMs. In addition, on the platform it was possible to form teams, whereas in our bootcamp rules that was completely ruled out, with everyone competing on their own.

There was also a time difference: when 6:00 p.m. came, we could no longer solve challenges, but the time on the platform kept running and, outside our bootcamp, there were still people competing. The OMNI CTF event even continued into the following day, at which point we were no longer allowed to compete, and moved on to solving the custom exercises created by the organisers. All of this gave me a sense of unfairness.

### Diversity of categories

The second-day CTF, customised by the bootcamp, did not have the same diversity of categories as the OMNI CTF. It became clear that, both at bootcamp level and worldwide, some categories ended up not being relevant for advancing, including my favourite one, OSINT.

I believe that, whether at bootcamp level or internationally, it is limiting to include only the main categories or those of greatest interest to the organisers. There are many other areas that deserved attention and that would give other participants the opportunity to shine. Cybersecurity is not just about what the majority does or what is considered more advanced; the more distinctive categories should be taken into account, not least because fewer people master them. This was evident at the OMNI CTF: brilliant participants, capable of solving exercises with extremely complex calculations, could not solve the most basic exercises in other, less conventional areas.



## Recommendations

- Standardise and enforce the same rules for all participants internationally, namely regarding the use of LLMs, team formation and time limits.
- Align the competition time windows to ensure equal conditions across regions.
- Include a greater diversity of categories, including OSINT, valuing different areas of cybersecurity.
- Increase the creativity and difficulty of the challenges, making the experience more challenging and accessible to all areas.





## Conclusion

It was a great pleasure to take part in this programme. The experience was very enriching, both technically and personally, and allowed me to learn a lot and to meet remarkable people from the national cybersecurity community. Although I was not selected for the next phase, I consider the overall outcome very positive and I am satisfied with my performance throughout all the stages.

I hope that, next year, the problems I identified will not be repeated and that the challenges will be even harder and more creative, making the experience more fun and accessible to all areas of cybersecurity.

# Thank You

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